

Look-Alike / Sound-Alike (LASA) Medication Management

Policy Number	POL-PH-033	Owner / Department	Pharmacy
Effective Date	2023-08-01	Version	2.0
Last Revised	2026-01-30	Next Review	2028-01-30
Approved By	Pharmacy & Therapeutics Committee	Applies To	All staff involved in procurement, storage, prescribing, dispensing, and administration of medications

1. Purpose

To reduce errors caused by medications whose names look alike or sound alike (LASA) through a managed LASA list, tall man lettering, storage separation, and verification at the point of care, consistent with ISMP guidance and The Joint Commission medication-management standards.

2. Definitions

- **LASA pair** — two drug names that are easily confused in print (look-alike) or speech (sound-alike), e.g., hydrALAZINE / hydrOXYzine.
- **Tall man lettering** — selective capitalization of dissimilar letters within similar names to highlight the difference (e.g., predniSONE / prednisoLONE).
- **Physical separation** — storing confusable products in non-adjacent locations or bins to break the error chain.

3. Policy and Procedure

Pharmacy maintains the facility LASA list (drawn from the ISMP list of confused drug names and local events), applies tall man lettering in the EHR, pharmacy system, labels, and automated dispensing cabinets, and reviews the list at least annually.

1. Store LASA pairs apart, with auxiliary “LASA” shelf and bin warnings.
2. Display tall man lettering wherever the drug name appears electronically or on a label.
3. Read back and confirm any verbal or telephone medication order, spelling the drug name.
4. Confirm the indication on orders for high-risk LASA pairs to disambiguate intent.
5. Verify the drug name against the order and the patient indication at administration using two patient identifiers.

IMPORTANT — For verbal and telephone medication orders, the receiver must write down and read back the complete order and spell the drug name letter by letter when it belongs to a LASA pair, before the medication is prepared or given.

4. Representative LASA Pairs

Name A	Name B	Risk
hydrALAZINE	hydrOXYzine	Look & sound-alike
predniSONE	prednisoLONE	Look-alike
DOPamine	DOBUtamine	Look & sound-alike
cefTRIAXone	cefTAZidime	Look-alike
HumaLOG	HumuLIN	Look & sound-alike
vinBLAStine	vinCRIStine	Look-alike; fatal if IT

5. Severity & Reporting

Classify LASA events on the POL-RM-013 scale and grade errors by the NCC MERP index per POL-PS-003. Even intercepted LASA mix-ups should be reported so the list and storage controls can be improved.

Severity	Example	Notify / timeframe
SEV-1	vinCRIStine given by wrong route; LASA swap contributing to death.	Provider, Nursing Supervisor & Risk Mgmt within 1 hour.
SEV-2	Wrong LASA drug reaching the patient with temporary harm needing treatment.	Provider & Risk Mgmt within 4 hours.
SEV-3 / Near Miss	LASA swap reaching patient without harm; mix-up caught at verification.	Event report within 24 hours.

6. Documentation Requirements

- Both drug names involved and the point in the process where confusion occurred.
- Whether tall man lettering and storage separation were in place.
- Read-back performed for any verbal/telephone order.
- Whether the error reached the patient and the NCC MERP category.

7. References

- ISMP List of Confused Drug Names.
- ISMP and FDA Tall Man Lettering lists.
- The Joint Commission medication-management standards (verbal/telephone order read-back).
- Related: POL-RM-013 (severity & reporting); POL-PS-003 (medication-error reporting); POL-PH-032 (high-alert medications).